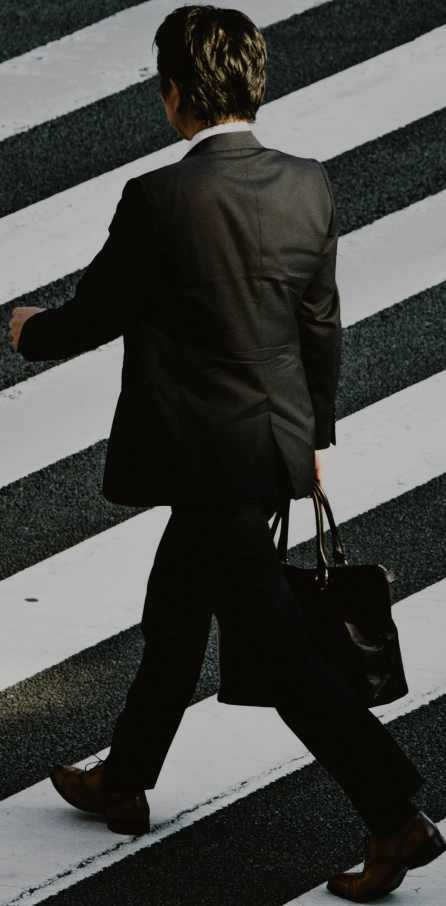


JUNE 2025

InternUp



THE "SOLOPRENEUR" SUCCESS EQUATION: DECODING THE DNA OF THRIVING ONE-PERSON COMPANIES

The Solopreneur Success Equation

A visual deep-dive into the data and strategies powering the "business-of-one" revolution.

81%

of small businesses are nonemployer firms, run by a single individual.

56%

of current solopreneurs launched their venture after 2020.

20%

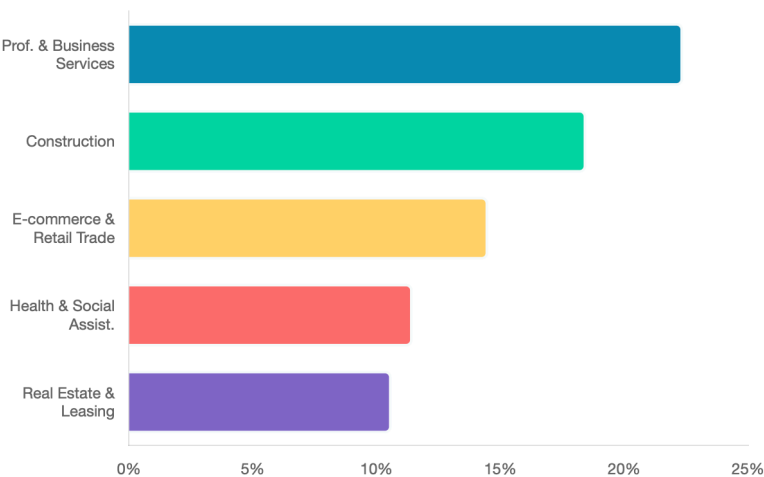
earn between \$100k-\$300k per year with zero employees.

The Market Landscape: Who Are They & What Do They Do?

The modern solopreneur defies stereotypes. The data reveals a mature, highly educated, and diverse cohort thriving not in tech, but in service-based industries.

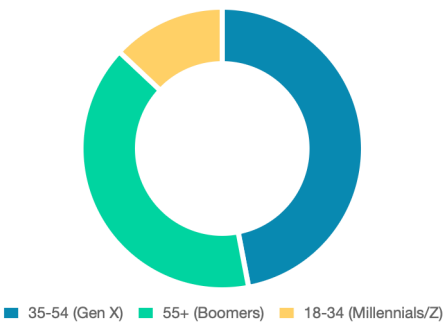
Dominant Industries for Solopreneurs

This chart shows the percentage of nonemployer firms by top sectors. Success is driven by professional expertise, not just tech wizardry.



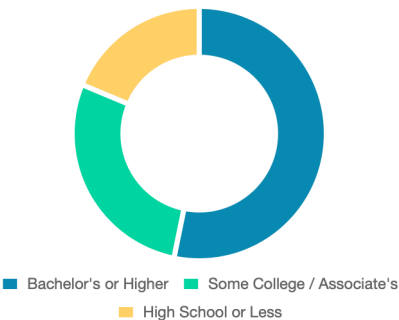
Founder Age Distribution

Experience is a key asset, with the majority of founders being over 35.



Founder Education Level

Solopreneurs are highly educated, leveraging formal training to build their ventures.



The Four Faces of Solopreneurship

Based on business models and motivations, four distinct archetypes emerge. Each has a unique path to success and a specific set of challenges to overcome.

The Specialist

The Expert-for-Hire

A high-value expert (consultant, coach) who solves complex problems for select clients. Their business is built on deep knowledge and a powerful personal brand.

Challenge: Scalability. Income is capped by hours.

The Creator

The Audience Builder

Builds a business by first building a loyal audience (YouTube, podcasts, newsletters). Their primary asset is the community's attention and trust.

Challenge: Monetization without losing authenticity.

The Maker

The Product Builder

Creates and sells a tangible or digital product, from e-commerce brands to SaaS apps. They are systems-thinkers and innovators.

Challenge: Marketing and customer acquisition at scale.

The Operator

The Agency-of-One

Runs a highly efficient, high-volume service business (e.g., design). They are masters of execution, process, and optimization.

Challenge: Burnout from juggling multiple clients.

The Duality of the Hustle: Why They Win & Why They Fail

Success and failure are two sides of the same coin. Winning strategies are the direct inverse of common pitfalls. The most successful solopreneurs often follow a proven evolutionary path.

Why They Win: Principles of Success

- ✓ **Systemize Over Selling Time:** Build a business, not just a job. Create products and processes that decouple revenue from hours worked.
- ✓ **Radical Niche Focus:** Solve a painful, urgent problem for a hyper-specific "Lighthouse Client." Become the best solution for that niche.
- ✓ **Build in Public:** Leverage your journey and expertise to build a personal brand. Transparency creates trust and a competitive moat.
- ✓ **Bias for Action:** Launch ideas quickly, even if imperfect. Real learning comes from market feedback, not endless analysis.

Why They Fail: Common Pitfalls

- ✗ **Lack of Planning & Focus:** Launching without a clear strategy leads to wasted effort on low-impact activities.
- ✗ **Ignoring Marketing & Sales:** Believing a great product will sell itself. Without a system to find customers, even the best offerings fail.
- ✗ **Poor Financial Management:** Running out of cash, pricing too low, and not tracking cash flow are common and fatal errors.
- ✗ **The "Do-It-All" Trap & Burnout:** Refusing to automate or delegate leads to exhaustion and becoming the bottleneck in your own business.

The De-Risked Path: Evolution from Service to Product

Many successful founders de-risk their journey by evolving their business model. They start with services to validate a market and then "productize" their solution to scale.

1. Direct Service

(Specialist / Operator)

Serve clients 1-on-1. This is paid market research.



2. Identify Patterns

Find recurring client problems and successful solutions.



3. Productize Solution

Package the solution into a scalable format.
(Course, Template, SaaS)



4. Scale

(Creator / Maker)

Reach a wider market, decoupling revenue from time.



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1. Executive Summary

- **Solopreneur Prevalence:** Single-person businesses constitute 81-84% of all small businesses in the U.S., with 29.8 million nonemployer businesses in 2022.
- **Solopreneur Demographics:** Typically experienced and educated, with 54% over 35 and 53.2% holding a Bachelor's degree or higher, and 54.4% being women.
- **Key Industries and Earnings:** Professional and Business Services (22.37%), Construction (18.46%), and Real Estate are key industries, with average revenues around \$47,794 and 20% achieving six-figure earnings.

The solopreneur economy has emerged as a dominant force, with single-person businesses constituting between 81% and 84% of all small businesses in the U.S.. In 2022, this segment grew to 29.8 million nonemployer businesses, a significant rise from 27.2 million in 2020. This growth is driven by diverse motivations; while 52% are "Strategists" seeking autonomy, a notable 33% are "Survivalists" driven by economic necessity.

The modern solopreneur is typically experienced and educated, with 54% over the age of 35 and 53.2% holding a Bachelor's degree or higher. Women are a significant force, making up 54.4% of this group. Contrary to popular belief, the solopreneur landscape is not dominated by tech. Key industries include Professional and Business Services (22.37%), Construction (18.46%), and Real Estate. While average revenues are around \$47,794, a notable 20% achieve six-figure earnings between \$100,000 and \$300,000 annually, primarily in service-based fields.

Success hinges on specific strategies: systemizing knowledge to decouple income from time, adopting a radical niche focus, building a personal brand, and maintaining a bias for action. Conversely, failure is often tied to a lack of planning, neglecting sales and marketing, poor financial management, and attempting to do everything without automation or delegation.

2. The State of the Solopreneur: A Market Landscape Analysis

- **Small businesses are the bedrock of the U.S. economy, with "businesses-of-one" being the most common model. This segment is growing rapidly, driven by a mix of individuals seeking autonomy and those needing to supplement insufficient wages.**

2.1 Scale, Growth, and Demographics

The modern economic landscape is being reshaped by a powerful, yet often underestimated, force: the solopreneur. While large corporations dominate headlines, small businesses form the true bedrock of the American economy, constituting 99.9% of all U.S. enterprises. Within this massive segment, the "business-of-one" has emerged as the dominant model. A staggering 81% to 84% of all small businesses are classified as "nonemployer" firms—the U.S. Census Bureau's designation for businesses run by a single individual without paid staff. In 2022, this amounted to 29.8 million nonemployer businesses, a substantial increase from 27.2 million in 2020, signaling a period of robust and sustained growth.

This movement is not monolithic; a closer look at motivations reveals a bifurcation in the market. While a majority are "Strategists" driven by the pursuit of autonomy, a significant cohort (33%) are "Survivalists" driven by necessity because their employers do not pay enough to make ends meet. This distinction is critical for understanding the varied needs and vulnerabilities within the solopreneur economy.

Which of the following, if any, best describe why you became self-employed?



Sample: 1,370 US adults (age 18+) who have started a self-employed business.

Source: Intuit QuickBooks "Entrepreneurship in 2024" Report. Online survey of 4,583 US adults with income from employment or self-employment, commissioned by Intuit QuickBooks in December 2023. • Embed



Exhibit 1:

“Reasons for Being Self-Employed”

Reference: <https://quickbooks.intuit.com/r/small-business-data/self-employment-trends-2024/>

The demographic profile of the modern solopreneur defies the youthful tech-founder stereotype, revealing a more mature, educated, and diverse cohort:

- **Age:** Experience is a key asset. 54% of solopreneurs are over the age of 35. A 2023 report estimates that 40% of small business owners are Baby Boomers and 47% are Gen X, indicating a strong trend of entrepreneurship well past traditional retirement ages. Simultaneously, younger generations are embracing this path, with 14.8% of solopreneurs aged 18-24.
- **Gender:** Women are a powerful force in this economy, comprising 54.4% of solopreneurs and owning 42.7% of all nonemployer firms in the U.S.. Since the pandemic, the growth rate of self-employment among women has outpaced that of men, particularly for those with young children at home.

- **Education:** Solopreneurs are highly educated. Over half (53.2%) hold a Bachelor's Degree or higher, leveraging their formal training and professional skills to build their ventures.
- **Geography:** While solopreneurship is a nationwide phenomenon, certain regions have become hotspots. Florida boasts the highest percentage of self-employed individuals in its workforce and the highest per capita rate of nonemployer firms in the nation.

Founder Demographics: Age & Gender

The modern solopreneur is typically experienced and educated. This diverse group is increasingly composed of women, who are a major driving force in this economy.

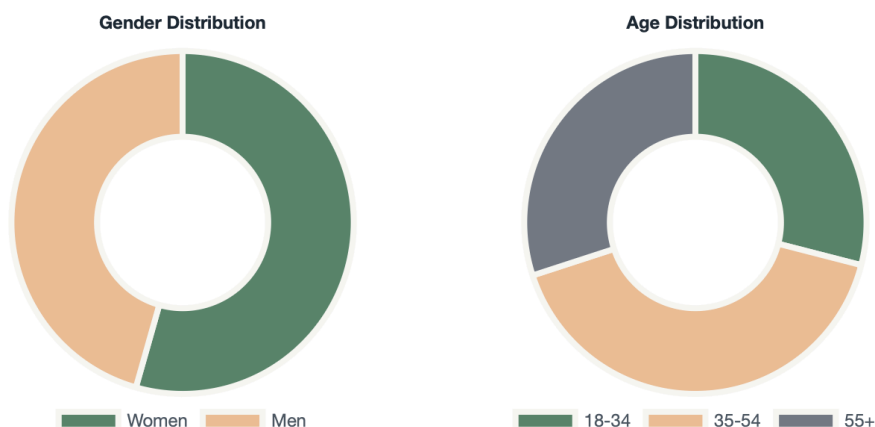


Exhibit 2:

“Founder Demographics”

Reference: <https://leapmesh.com/solopreneur-statistics/>

2.2 Dominant Industries and Financial Realities

Contrary to the media's focus on high-tech startups, the solopreneur economy thrives in established, service-oriented sectors. Only 10% of solopreneurs originate from technology-related fields. The dominant industries, according to 2021 data, are Professional and Business Services (22.37%), Construction (18.46%), and Education and Health Services (11.45%). U.S. Census data from 2022 further reinforces this, identifying Professional, Scientific, and Technical Services; Transportation and Warehousing; and Real Estate, Rental and Leasing as the three largest sectors by number of nonemployer establishments.

Top Industries for Nonemployer Firms

Success isn't confined to tech. Service-based sectors like professional services, real estate, and construction dominate the landscape, highlighting the value of specialized skills.

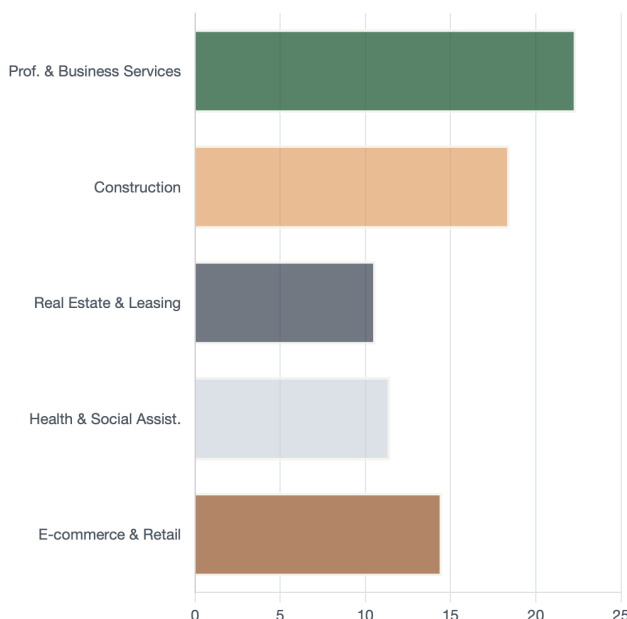


Exhibit 3:

“Top Industries for Nonemployer Firms”

Reference: <https://bizstack.tech/solopreneur-statistics/>

The financial performance of solopreneurs varies widely. The average revenue for a nonemployer firm is approximately \$47,794, with other sources citing an average solopreneur income around \$69,000 annually. However, a significant and highly visible segment achieves substantial success. An impressive 20% of solopreneurs earn between \$100,000 and \$300,000 per year without any staff. These high-earners are most often found in service-based fields like consulting, coaching, and specialized

professional services, where deep expertise commands premium rates. At the highest end, a small fraction (3.6%) generate over \$83,000 per month, and a handful of firms in sectors like Finance and Insurance even exceed \$5 million in annual receipts without employees.

Annual Revenue Distribution

While average income is modest, a significant portion of solopreneurs achieve six-figure earnings, proving the high-earning potential of a well-run solo business. Hover over the bars to see details.



Exhibit 4:

“Annual Revenue Distribution”

Reference: <https://www.venasolutions.com/blog/small-business-revenue-statistics>

While these figures are aspirational, the definition of success is subjective. A recent survey found that solopreneurs feel they need to earn an average of \$219,000 per year

to feel truly successful, a figure that reflects not just business costs but also the desire for financial stability and personal fulfillment. This highlights that the most accessible and proven path to a six-figure solo business is not by inventing a novel technology, but by productizing a high-value skill and delivering it through a service-based model.

Industry Sector	% of Nonemployer Firms	Common Business Models	Typical Revenue Range	Key Success Levers
Professional, Scientific & Technical Services	13.5%	Consulting, Coaching, Freelance Services (Writing, Design), Fractional Executive	\$75,000 - \$250,000+	Expertise & Personal Brand, Client Relationships, High-Value Problem Solving
Construction	9.6%	Independent Contractor, Specialized Trades (e.g., electrical, plumbing), Project Management	\$60,000 - \$150,000+	Craftsmanship & Reputation, Local Network & Referrals, Project Management
Real Estate, Rental & Leasing	10.6%	Real Estate Agent, Property Manager, Real Estate Investor	\$50,000 - \$200,000+	Market Knowledge, Networking, Deal Sourcing & Negotiation
E-commerce & Retail Trade	14.5% (Combined)	Dropshipping, Private Label, Digital Products, Print-on-Demand, Niche Online Store	\$40,000 - \$100,000+	Marketing & SEO, Supply Chain Management, Customer Acquisition, Technology Platform
Health Care & Social Assistance	11.45% (Combined with Education)	Telehealth Provider, Private Practice Therapist/ Counselor, Wellness Coach	\$60,000 - \$180,000+	Specialized Credentials, Client Trust & Confidentiality, Digital Platforms (Telehealth)

Table 1:

“Solopreneur Industry & Revenue Snapshot”

3. The Four Faces of Solopreneurship: Operator Archetypes

- **The solopreneur economy consists of four main archetypes: Specialists who sell expertise, Creators who build audiences, Makers who build products, and Operators who run efficient service businesses. Each archetype faces unique challenges related to scalability, audience growth, product-market fit, or operational burnout**

The solopreneur economy is not a monolith. Based on an analysis of business models, motivations, and technology adoption, four distinct operator archetypes emerge. Understanding these archetypes provides a framework for identifying specific challenges and strategic pathways to success.

3.1 The Specialist: The Expert-for-Hire

Profile: The Specialist is a high-value expert whose business is built on deep domain knowledge and a powerful personal brand. This archetype includes consultants, executive coaches, public speaking trainers, and elite freelance professionals who solve complex, high-stakes problems for a select clientele.

Motivation: Their primary drivers are autonomy and impact. They are passionate about their craft and seek the freedom to control the quality of their work, choose their clients, and see the direct results of their expertise.

Business Model: Revenue is generated through high-ticket services, one-on-one coaching packages, corporate training engagements, and long-term retainers. While income is often linked to time, it is at a significant premium, reflecting their specialized value.

Core Challenge: The fundamental challenge for the Specialist is **scalability**. Their income is ultimately capped by the number of hours in a day. The key strategic imperative is to evolve from "doing" the work to "systematizing" their knowledge into

scalable formats, such as group coaching, online courses, or licensed intellectual property.

Tech Stack: The Specialist's tech stack is lean and focused on client management and brand projection. A robust **Customer Relationship Management (CRM)** tool like HubSpot or Folk is essential for nurturing high-value relationships. **Scheduling tools** like Calendly or Tidycal are critical for efficiently managing their most valuable asset: time. Their online presence is anchored by a professional, content-rich **website** (often built on platforms like Squarespace or Wix) that serves as a digital storefront for their expertise.

3.2 The Creator: The Audience Builder

Profile: The Creator builds a business by first building a loyal audience. This group includes YouTubers, podcasters, newsletter authors, and online course creators who consistently produce valuable content for a specific niche. Their primary asset is the attention and trust of their community.

Motivation: Creators are driven by a passion for their subject matter and a desire for creative expression. They are motivated by the act of sharing knowledge and connecting with a like-minded community.

Business Model: Revenue is decoupled from time and generated through a variety of monetization strategies targeting their audience. These include selling **digital products** (courses, e-books, templates), offering **subscriptions or memberships** for premium content, leveraging **affiliate marketing**, and securing **sponsorships**.

Core Challenge: The dual challenge for the Creator is **consistent audience growth and effective monetization**. They face constant pressure to produce high-quality content to attract and retain followers, while simultaneously finding ways to convert that attention into sustainable revenue without compromising the authenticity that built their audience in the first place.

Tech Stack: The Creator's stack is centered on content production, distribution, and monetization. **Email Marketing Platforms** like ConvertKit or Beehiiv are the central nervous system for audience communication. **Course and Membership Platforms** such as Kajabi, Teachable, or Ghost provide the infrastructure for selling digital

products. **AI-powered content tools** like Descript (for audio/video) and Jasper (for writing) are increasingly used to streamline production and increase output.

3.3 The Maker: The Product Builder

Profile: The Creator builds a business by first building a loyal audience. This group includes YouTubers, podcasters, newsletter authors, and online course creators who consistently produce valuable content for a specific niche. Their primary asset is the attention and trust of their community.

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3.4 The Operator: The Agency-of-One

Profile: The Operator runs a highly efficient, often high-volume, service business. This archetype includes web designers, graphic designers, social media managers, and

virtual assistants who have perfected their processes to handle multiple clients simultaneously. They are masters of execution and optimization.

Motivation: Operators are often motivated by a combination of financial reward and the deep satisfaction of running a well-oiled machine. They thrive on creating smooth, repeatable systems and delivering consistent results.

Business Model: Their model is based on delivering project-based services or monthly retainers. They often use a tiered pricing structure to cater to different client needs and budgets, which allows them to maximize revenue across their client base.

Core Challenge: The greatest risks for the Operator are **burnout and administrative complexity**. Juggling numerous clients, projects, communications, and deadlines creates a high potential for overwhelm. Their primary strategic focus must be on streamlining workflows to maintain profitability and sanity.

Tech Stack: The Operator's stack is laser-focused on operational efficiency. **Project Management Tools** like ClickUp, Asana, or Trello serve as the central command center for all client work. **Automation Platforms** such as Zapier and Make are non-negotiable for connecting different software and eliminating time-consuming manual tasks. **Financial Tools** like QuickBooks or Wave are necessary for invoicing, tracking expenses, and ensuring profitability on a per-project basis.

4. Narratives of Success and Failure

- Thriving solopreneurs build systems, focus on a specific niche, cultivate a personal brand, and prioritize action over analysis. Failure often results from the opposite: no business plan, ignoring marketing, poor financial oversight, and burnout from trying to do it all.

4.1 Leading Vendors and Market Positioning

An analysis of successful solopreneur case studies, interviews, and podcasts reveals a consistent set of underlying principles that transcend industry and business model. These are the common threads in the DNA of thriving one-person companies.

First, successful solopreneurs prioritize **systemization over selling time**. They intentionally build a business, not just a job for themselves. This involves creating repeatable processes, automating workflows, and developing products or services that decouple revenue from the direct exchange of hours for money. The journey of a consultant like Justin Welsh, who evolved his one-on-one services into scalable online courses, exemplifies this transition from a time-based to a system-based business.

Second, they embrace **radical niche focus**. Instead of attempting to serve a broad market, they identify a very specific "Lighthouse Client"—a clearly defined customer profile with a painful, urgent problem—and dedicate themselves to becoming the undisputed best solution for that niche. This focus simplifies all aspects of the business, from marketing messaging to product development. The case of Nausheen Chen, who built a thriving practice by focusing exclusively on public speaking coaching for executives, demonstrates the power of this strategy.

Third, they understand the power of **building in public and cultivating a personal brand**. They leverage their unique story, expertise, and journey to build a brand that serves as both a powerful marketing engine and a formidable competitive moat. By transparently sharing their progress, including both wins and failures, they build deep trust and attract a loyal community of followers and potential customers.

Finally, they maintain a bias for **action over analysis**. They avoid the "analysis paralysis" that plagues many aspiring entrepreneurs by launching their ideas quickly, even if imperfectly. They understand that real learning comes from market feedback,

not from endless planning. The mantra is to "start, then think," iterating and refining their approach based on real-world data and customer interactions.

4.2 Common Pitfalls: Learning from Failure

The reasons why solopreneur ventures fail are often the mirror image of the factors that drive success. A thematic analysis of founder stories and business post-mortems reveals several recurring and fatal pitfalls.

The most common mistakes include:

- **Lack of Planning and Focus:** Nearly one-third of entrepreneurs launch without a formal business plan. This absence of a strategic roadmap leads to a lack of clear goals, wasted effort on low-impact activities, and an inability to navigate challenges effectively.
 - **Ignoring Marketing and Sales:** Many solopreneurs are masters of their craft but novices in business development. They fall into the trap of believing a great product or service will sell itself, neglecting the critical work of building a marketing engine and learning how to sell. Without a system to attract and convert customers, even the best offerings will fail.
 - **Poor Financial Management:** This is a frequent cause of failure. Common errors include running out of cash due to inadequate capitalization, setting prices too low to be profitable, failing to track cash flow, and not separating business and personal finances.
 - **The "Do-It-All" Trap and Burnout:** A refusal or inability to automate, delegate, or outsource tasks inevitably leads to the solopreneur becoming the primary bottleneck in their own business. This attempt to handle every single task results in exhaustion, reduced quality of work, and ultimately, severe burnout.
 - **No Market Need:** A fundamental error is building a solution for a problem that doesn't exist, isn't urgent, or that customers are not willing to pay to solve. This often stems from a lack of upfront market research and validation.
-

5. Sample Roadmap

The Solopreneur's 90-Day Launch Plan

- A successful launch requires a structured 90-day plan focusing on foundational, activation, and optimization phases. Key actions include defining a "Lighthouse Client," establishing legal and financial basics, launching a simple website, activating a marketing channel, and implementing a minimal tech stack to systematize operations from day one.

Focus Area	Month 1: Foundation	Month 2: Activation	Month 3: Optimization
Strategy & Planning	Define "Lighthouse Client" profile. Create a one-page business plan outlining value proposition, target market, and revenue goals.	Refine service/product offering based on initial feedback. Set clear 30-day revenue and client acquisition targets.	Conduct a post-mortem on the first 90 days. Develop a 6-month strategic roadmap.
Legal & Finance	Choose a legal structure (e.g., LLC) and register the business. Open a separate business bank account. Set up accounting software (e.g., Wave).	Create invoice templates and a system for tracking payments. Estimate quarterly taxes and set aside funds.	Analyze Month 1-2 cash flow. Create a simple budget and profitability forecast for the next quarter.
Branding & Marketing	Secure domain name. Build a simple one-page website or landing page (e.g., using Carrd). Choose one primary social media channel and optimize your profile.	Activate your network with a launch email. Post valuable content on your primary channel 3-5 times per week.	Analyze which content resonates most. Secure one client testimonial or case study. Begin building an email list.

Tech & Operations	Set up your Minimum Viable Tech Stack (See Table 2). Create a project management board (e.g., Trello) for your launch tasks.	Automate one repetitive task using Zapier (e.g., saving new leads to a spreadsheet). Systemize your client onboarding process with a checklist.	Identify and automate a second workflow. Conduct a time audit to find efficiency gains.
Personal & Mindset	Join one online community or forum for solopreneurs. Set and commit to daily work start/end times.	Find an accountability partner or mentor. Schedule one non-work activity during the work week to enforce boundaries.	Practice the "Anti-Burnout Protocol." Reflect on wins and challenges. Celebrate progress made.

Table 2:

“The Solopreneur's 90-Day Launch Plan”

6. The Solopreneur's Minimum Viable Tech Stack

- **Technology can be overwhelming. The key is to start with a simple, integrated, and affordable stack that covers core business functions, preventing tool overload and unnecessary expense. The philosophy is to choose tools that can scale with the business and connect with each other, primarily through automation platforms like Zapier or Make.**

Function	Recommended Tool (Budget Start)	Recommended Tool (Growth)	Primary Archetype User	Key Benefit
Website/ Landing Page	Carrd	Webflow	Maker, Creator	Fast, simple page creation vs. powerful, customizable site building.
CRM/Contact Management	Notion	HubSpot CRM (Free/Starter)	Specialist, Operator	A flexible database vs. a dedicated, all-in-one client relationship platform.
Payments	Stripe / PayPal	QuickBooks	All Archetypes	Simple transaction processing vs. integrated invoicing and accounting.
Scheduling	Tidycal	Calendly	Specialist, Operator	Cost-effective appointment booking vs. advanced features and integrations.
Project Management	Trello	ClickUp / Asana	Operator, Maker	Visual, simple task tracking vs. comprehensive, all-in-one project hubs.
Automation	Zapier (Free Plan)	Zapier / Make (Paid Plans)	All Archetypes	Basic task automation vs. complex, multi-step workflow automation.

Email Marketing	Mailchimp (Free Plan)	ConvertKit / Beehiiv	Creator, Specialist	Simple email campaigns vs. advanced automation for creators and segmentation.
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Table 3:

“Minimum Viable Tech Stack”

7.1 Glossary of Terms

- **Nonemployer Firm:** The U.S. Census Bureau's official designation for a business with no paid employees, typically run by a single individual.
- **Lighthouse Client:** A clearly defined ideal customer profile with an urgent and painful problem that a solopreneur can solve, used to focus marketing and service development.
- **Minimum Viable Tech Stack:** A core set of affordable and integrated software tools covering essential business functions like payments, scheduling, and project management to ensure operational efficiency from the start.
- **Strategists vs. Survivalists:** A classification of solopreneurs based on motivation. "Strategists" are pulled into self-employment by the pursuit of autonomy and passion. "Survivalists" are pushed into it by economic necessity, such as insufficient pay from traditional employment.

7.2 Data Sources & Methodology

The analysis of the solopreneur market is based on data from official government sources and industry reports. The number and growth of nonemployer firms are derived from U.S. Census Bureau data from 2020 and 2022. Demographic information, including motivations, age, gender, and education levels, is sourced from the Intuit QuickBooks "Entrepreneurship in 2024 Report," which surveyed 4,583 U.S. adults in December 2023. Additional statistics on solopreneur industries and financial

performance were compiled from reports by Leapmesh and BizStak. Case studies and success principles were synthesized from an analysis of interviews and content from prominent solopreneurs.

7.3 Assumptions & Limitations

The financial data presented, such as average revenue, represents a broad cross-section of industries and may not reflect the earning potential within a specific niche. The "reasons for being self-employed" are based on a survey and may be subject to self-reporting biases. The archetypes identified are analytical frameworks; individual solopreneurs may exhibit characteristics of multiple archetypes. The report assumes that the trends observed in the U.S. market are indicative of broader shifts in developed economies, though regional variations exist.

Reference:

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